Sony CRX320EE
The top performer

FEATURES

Speeds

The write speed of a CD-R has a limit of 52x (7800 KBps), and all the Combo drives were capable of writing at this speed. Likewise, barring the Sony CRX320EE which could write to a CD-RW at 24x, the rest could manage 32x.

The read speed for CD-ROM has reached a limit of 52x, and that for a DVD-ROM is 16x. This indicates that today's Combo drives should perform equally well, but this is not so—as we shall see in the performance tests.

Other Features

All the drives have the IDE interface, and they are capable of DMA transfer mode. In this mode, as opposed to the older PIO mode, the device consumes very little CPU time, leaving more free resources for the PC to do other work.

The buffer memory was uniform, with each drive coming with 2 MB. A larger buffer memory is not really necessary these days because of the increase in speed of the interface.

A good-quality tray indicates, statistically, that the drive will last longer. The Lite-On and Sony drives had better-quality trays. Compared to them, the Samsung and LG drives' trays seemed wobbly and a little weaker.

The drives performed remarkably silent while writing; while reading, the Sony was the quietest. A noisy drive is irritating, and statistically, prone to early failure (probably because of poorer mechanical components).

Bundled Goodies

Only Sony provides a data cable with the drive, which earns it valuable brownie points. The other brands cut costs by excluding this essential component, which costs only around Rs 50.

Earlier, one CD-R and CD-RW used to be bundled with Combo drives, which isn't the case now since the drives don't come at a premium.

On the software front, each drive came with some version of Nero. The LG and Lite-On drives came with CyberLink PowerDVD for DVD video playback, and with the OEM version of Nero for burning. The Samsung and Sony came with Nero 6 and Nero 7 Essentials respectively, each with Nero Showtime as a component— a DVD-video playback software.

Lite-On SOHC-5232K
You can't go any cheaper!

PERFORMANCE

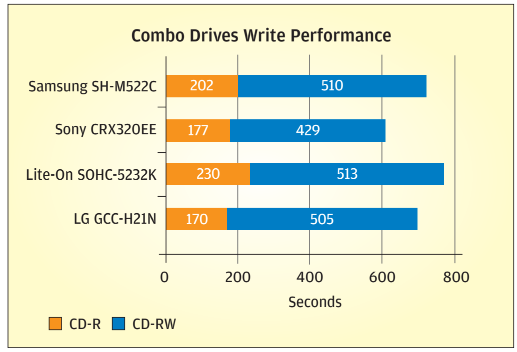
Read Performance

To gauge the read performance, we used Nero CD/DVD Speed. A stamped—as opposed to a burnt—CD and DVD were used for this test. The LG GCC-H21N had a speed of 11.81x, while the Lite-On was close behind with 11.58x (with a DVD). Installing applications and copying data from these drives will therefore be much faster than with the other two drives: 10.52x for the Sony and 10.97x for the Samsung. With a CD, the Lite-On and Samsung drives were neck-and-neck.

The access time test for CD and DVD produced mixed results. While the Lite-On and LG prevailed in the DVD test, the Lite-On and Samsung topped the CD test with the fastest access times. Faster access times means copying assorted data faster.

In both the audio CD ripping and DVD ripping tests, the drives clocked more or less similar timings. You'll have no problems listening to audio CDs or watching DVD movies with any of these drives.

In SiSoft Sandra, the LG scored 7.9 MBps, while the others were faster at 9 MBps. The access times of the Sony and Lite-On were much better than those of the other two.



Write Performance

The LG burnt the assorted CD at 52x in just 170 seconds and the sequential CD in 165 seconds—a clear leader as far as writing to CD-R is concerned. The Lite-On was the slowest; it could only write at 32x to the 52x-certified Moser Baer CD-R.

The Sony CRX320EE was exceptionally fast, writing to CD-RW at 12x (even when the media was marked 10x!). The other drives managed to write at 10x, and clocked almost similar timings to get the job done. This is funny because 24x is the CD-RW writing speed specified for the Sony, which is lower than the 32x for the others.

DVD-WRITERS

Combo drives as a species is speeding towards extinction, and we cautiously state that this may well be the last time they are being tested. DVD as a media is much cheaper per MB than a CD. Further, it backs up data faster, and a single-layer DVD can hold over seven times the amount of data as compared to a CD.

To back up most movies, which usually occupy space larger than a single-layer DVD or 4.7 GB, you require a dual-layer DVD (if you don't resort to compromising the video quality and removing some features using tools such as DVDShrink). A lot of new games, too, have dual-layer install disks, and to be able to back up so much data, you require a dual-layer DVD media and recorder. Thus, the DVD-Writer is already poised to become the *de facto* optical storage device for the majority of home users.

We received eight DVD-Writers from five brands: the Asus QuieTrack DRW-1612BL, Asus DRW-1608P2, LG GSA-H12N, Lite-On LightScribe SHM-165H6S, Lite-On Super AllWrite LH-16A1P, Lite-On Super AllWrite LH-20A1P, Samsung Super-WriteMaster SH-S182D, and the Sony AW-G170A.